2.3.3 Illustrating the stories with examples

Once you have some features and stories of value, you can start to explore them in more detail. One very effective way to do this is to ask the users and other stakeholders for concrete examples.

When you hear a user asking for a feature, you'll often immediately start to build a conceptual model of the problem you'll need to solve. In doing so, it's easy to let implicit and unstated assumptions cloud your understanding, leading to an inaccurate mental model and an incorrect implementation further down the line. Asking the stakeholders to give you concrete examples of what they mean is a great way to test and confirm your understanding of the problem.

For example, you might have the following exchange with Jill, the rail network domain expert:[3]

> You: Can you give me an example of a commuter travelling between two stations?
>
> Jill: Sure, how about going from Parramatta to Town Hall.
>
> You: And what would that look like?
>
> Jill: Well, they'd have to take the Western line. That's a heavily used line, and there are between eight and sixteen trains per hour, depending on the time of day. We'd just need to propose the next scheduled trips on that line.
>
> You: Can you give me an example of a trip where a commuter would have the choice of more than one line?
>
> Jill: Yes, a commuter going from Epping to Central could take the Epping line or the Northern line. The trip time will vary from about 27 minutes to around 43 minutes, and trains from any of these lines would typically be arriving every couple of minutes, so we'd need to give commuters enough information on departure and arrival times for the trains on both lines.

Even in this simple example, you can see that there are some subtleties. It's not always a simple matter of proposing the next train; you have to give the commuter details about departure and arrival times for all the scheduled upcoming trains.

2.4 Implementation: building and delivering features

Once you understand the features your application needs, you have to build them. In this section, we'll look at the core BDD lifecycle.

You'll learn how to take the business-focused examples we discussed in the previous section, and rewrite them in the form of executable specifications. You'll see how you can automate these specifications, and how doing so leads to discovering what

[3] You can follow along with these examples by referring to the map in figure 2.1.